MODULE 35 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

How CCAR-P Questions Are Written

The anatomy of an item, the qualifiers that decide it, part versus complete solutions, the distractor families, a method for every item, and timing.

SCOPE All seven domains FOCUS Question craft MODULE 35 of 38

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A good detective reads the question before the case file. **The question tells you which facts matter.**

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The anatomy of an item

PART	WHAT IT HOLDS	READ IT FOR
Stem	Client, current state, what went wrong	The hard constraints
Goal	What the client wants	The priority
Qualifier	First, most directly, BEFORE, without degrading	What best means here
Select count	One, or choose two	Whether picks combine or stand alone
Options	Four or five, all plausible	Which one breaks nothing

THE TIEBREAKER

The stem supplies constraints. The last line supplies the rule for choosing.

Qualifiers, and what they demand

QUALIFIER	WHAT IT DEMANDS
FIRST	The step that defines good, or diagnoses, before any change
MOST directly	The option that removes the cause in one move
BEFORE X	Steps that sit earlier in the sequence than X
Best fit	Meets every constraint with the least machinery
Without degrading X	X is a hard constraint: strike anything that risks it
Least operational effort	Built-in or managed beats custom

THE TIEBREAKER

Circle the qualifier before reading the options. It is the rule the options are judged by.

Choose two: part of the solution, or a complete solution?

EACH CORRECT ANSWER PRESENTS PART OF THE SOLUTION

Two halves of one answer

- Neither pick works alone
- Together they form one fix
- Often a control plus its evidence
- Check the two combine without conflict

EACH CORRECT ANSWER PRESENTS A COMPLETE SOLUTION

Two separate answers

- Each pick works on its own
- Two different ways to solve it
- Often two valid architectures
- Check each one stands alone

THE TIEBREAKER

Read the instruction under the question. It changes how the two picks relate.

The distractor families

FAMILY	LOOKS LIKE
Detective for a preventive need	An audit or alert when the harm must be stopped
Right idea, wrong layer	A prompt instruction for an authorisation rule
Optimises a non-binding constraint	Cheaper, when the problem is latency
Skips a step	Builds or switches before defining or testing
True but not an answer	A correct statement that does not address the question
Newest-feature bait	Names a new feature the problem does not need

THE TIEBREAKER

Name the family, and the option is gone. Most wrong options belong to one of these six.

A method for every item

01
Last line
Read the question first.

02
Mark it
Qualifier and select count.

03
Constraints
Find them in the stem.

04
Strike
Anything that breaks one.

05
Choose
Simplest option that meets the priority.

06
Re-check
Against the qualifier.

ON THE EXAM

Eliminate on constraints, then optimise on the qualifier. Never the other way round.

Timing and tactics

- **63 items in 120 minutes:** just under two minutes each.
- **First pass:** answer what you can within two minutes; flag the rest and move on.
- **Second pass:** return to flagged items with the time you saved.
- **Answer every item.** An unanswered item cannot score.
- **Change an answer only** when you find a reason in the stem, not a feeling.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Pass mark: a scaled 720 out of 1,000. Domain scores are feedback, not separate hurdles.

> Tallyhawk's billing agent occasionally issues refunds above the approved limit.
>
> The limit is written in the system prompt.

Which change MOST directly prevents refunds above the limit?

A. Enforce the limit in the refund tool's code, rejecting any amount above it

B. Repeat the limit more firmly in the system prompt, with an example

C. Audit all refunds daily, and reverse any above the limit

D. Move the agent to a more capable model tier

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which change MOST directly prevents refunds above the limit?

A Enforce the limit in the refund tool's code, rejecting any amount above it

Preventive, at the right layer.

B Repeat the limit more firmly in the system prompt, with an example

Right idea, wrong layer.

C Audit all refunds daily, and reverse any above the limit

Detective for a preventive need.

D Move the agent to a more capable model tier

Optimises the wrong thing.

THE SIGNAL

Most directly: remove the cause in one move, at the layer that can enforce it.

> Quillon wants to cut the portal's running cost.
>
> The contract requires 92% on the evaluation set and first token within 2 seconds at p95.

Which change reduces cost WITHOUT degrading either requirement?

A Move all portal questions to the Batch API

B Cache the stable policy and instructions in a prompt prefix

C Move every question to the smallest model tier now

D Halve the retrieved context sent with each question

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which change reduces cost WITHOUT degrading either requirement?

A Move all portal questions to the Batch API

Breaks the latency requirement.

B Cache the stable policy and instructions in a prompt prefix

Zero risk to both requirements.

C Move every question to the smallest model tier now

Risks the quality floor, untested.

D Halve the retrieved context sent with each question

Risks the quality floor.

THE SIGNAL

Without degrading X makes X a hard constraint. Strike every option that risks it.

> Mereside added a new complaint category to triage last week.
>
> Accuracy fell for that category only, and the others are unchanged.

What should the team do FIRST?

A Note that language models can hallucinate, so some errors are expected

B Move triage to a more capable model tier

C Reproduce the failures on the evaluation set, and review the new category's definition and examples

D Retrain the classifier on last month's complaints

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the team do FIRST?

A Note that language models can hallucinate, so some errors are expected

True, but not an answer.

B Move triage to a more capable model tier

Skips diagnosis.

C Reproduce the failures on the evaluation set, and review the new category's definition and examples

Diagnose before changing anything.

D Retrain the classifier on last month's complaints

Skips diagnosis, wrong mechanism.

THE SIGNAL

First means diagnose. A true statement that does not answer the question is still wrong.

> Tallyhawk needs each closed ticket summarised into three fields for its CRM: issue, resolution and follow-up.
>
> The steps never vary.

Which design is the BEST fit?

A. A team of agents, one per field, coordinated by an orchestrator

B. An autonomous agent with tools to read and update the CRM

C. A model fine-tuned on past ticket summaries

D. A single model call with a structured output schema, written to the CRM by code

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which design is the BEST fit?

A. A team of agents, one per field, coordinated by an orchestrator
Machinery the task does not need.

B. An autonomous agent with tools to read and update the CRM
Autonomy the task does not need.

C. A model fine-tuned on past ticket summaries
Not the lever here.

D. A single model call with a structured output schema, written to the CRM by code
Least machinery that meets the need.

THE SIGNAL

Best fit: every constraint met, with the least machinery.

> Mereside's staff policy assistant showed a member of staff a paraphrase of an HR-restricted procedure.
>
> Each correct answer presents part of the solution.

Which two changes together fix the problem? Choose two.

A Filter retrieval by each user's entitlements, before passages reach Claude

B Instruct Claude in the system prompt never to reveal restricted content

C Hide restricted passages when the answer is displayed

D Move the assistant to a separate, more capable model

E Log each retrieval with the user's identity, and audit access to restricted documents

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two changes together fix the problem? Choose two.

A Filter retrieval by each user's entitlements, before passages reach Claude

Prevents the leak at the source.

B Instruct Claude in the system prompt never to reveal restricted content

Wrong layer.

C Hide restricted passages when the answer is displayed

Too late: Claude already read it.

D Move the assistant to a separate, more capable model

Irrelevant to access.

E Log each retrieval with the user's identity, and audit access to restricted documents

Evidence that the control works.

THE SIGNAL

Part of the solution: a control plus its evidence, which only work together.

> Tallyhawk's integration-fault agent loads about one hundred and forty MCP tools up front, filling much of its context.
>
> Each correct answer presents a complete solution.

Which two changes would each, on its own, cut the context used by tool definitions? Choose two.

A Put a router agent in front of the existing agent

B Raise the max tokens limit for each response

C Turn on tool search with deferred loading, keeping a few frequently used tools loaded

D Split the agent by domain, each part loading only its own tools

E Move to a model with a larger context window

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two changes would each, on its own, cut the context used by tool definitions? Choose two.

A Put a router agent in front of the existing agent
Adds a hop; the agent still loads every tool.

B Raise the max tokens limit for each response
Limits output, not definitions.

C Turn on tool search with deferred loading, keeping a few frequently used tools loaded
Complete on its own.

D Split the agent by domain, each part loading only its own tools
Complete on its own.

E Move to a model with a larger context window
More room, same waste.

THE SIGNAL

A complete solution stands alone. Check each pick independently.

> Tallyhawk's support agent meets every target on its evaluation set.
>
> A product lead proposes adopting two newly released platform features "to stay current". No gap or requirement is named.

What should Corvane recommend?

A. Adopt both features now, so the agent keeps pace with the platform

B. Keep the current design, and adopt a feature only when a requirement or measured gap calls for it, tested on the evaluation set

C. Adopt one of the two features as a compromise, and review the other next quarter

D. Rebuild the agent on a different framework that includes both features

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should Corvane recommend?

A. Adopt both features now, so the agent keeps pace with the platform
Newest-feature bait.

B. Keep the current design, and adopt a feature only when a requirement or measured gap calls for it, tested on the evaluation set
Requirement first, then evaluate.

C. Adopt one of the two features as a compromise, and review the other next quarter
Still adopts without a reason.

D. Rebuild the agent on a different framework that includes both features
Large change, no stated need.

THE SIGNAL

A new feature is an answer only when the problem asks for it.

> Tallyhawk wants Claude to review every pull request across its repositories.
>
> The requirement is the LEAST operational effort.

Which approach fits this requirement?

A. Build a custom webhook service that calls the Claude API for each pull request

B. Host an agent framework on Tallyhawk's own servers to watch the repositories

C. Use the Claude Code GitHub Action in CI, with the team's review instructions

D. Ask developers to run a review in their terminal before opening each pull request

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which approach fits this requirement?

A Build a custom webhook service that calls the Claude API for each pull request

Custom code to build and run.

B Host an agent framework on Tallyhawk's own servers to watch the repositories

Infrastructure to build and run.

C Use the Claude Code GitHub Action in CI, with the team's review instructions

Built-in, managed in CI.

D Ask developers to run a review in their terminal before opening each pull request

Manual, and easily skipped.

THE SIGNAL

Least operational effort favours built-in and managed options over custom ones.

In five lines

- **Read the last line first;** mark the qualifier and the select count.
- **Constraints from the stem;** strike anything that breaks one.
- **Part of the solution** combines; **a complete solution** stands alone.
- **Name the distractor family,** and the option is gone.
- **Two minutes an item;** flag, return, answer everything.

COMING UP

Next: practice paper 1, twenty-one new questions.